

Honor 90

Premium looks, stunning display, but underpowered for the price

After a hiatus of about three years, Honor is back in India with a spanking new smartphone launch! The smartphone in question is the Honor 90 – a mid-range smartphone that serves looks. You've got absolute monster performers such as the iQOO Neo 7 Pro and OnePlus Nord 3 inhabiting this price segment, so let's see if the new Honor 90 can actually give these a run for their money. If you're wondering if you should buy the new Honor 90, read on.

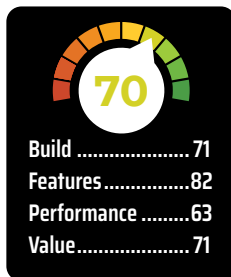
BUILD AND DESIGN

The Honor 90 is absolutely stunning. All three colours have different textures and designs; and they each have their own charm, in my opinion. It curves beautifully against the contours of my hand and the overall feel of using the phone is fantastic because of how thin and lightweight it is. The weight distribution is also excellent. The two circular camera modules have a lot of design flair as well. The front of the phone looks like a work of art as well because Honor has curved the display from all four sides. The top and bottom have a slightly less pronounced curve, but it still makes the phone look more premium than most competitors in this price bracket.

The sides of the phone are made out of plastic and the buttons on the right side are well-built and tactile. The company has claimed that this glass is extremely tough. I myself have tested it out by cracking a walnut shell (encouraged by Honor's 'Walnut challenge') with it and dropping it from waist height – no damage was done. Sadly though, there's no IP rating, which is disappointing because it would take the phone's survivability to the next level.

The phone also misses out on stereo speakers, which I think, is almost inexcusable

₹37,999



able at the sub-₹40K price point. Speaker and display protection aside, I think this is one of my favourite designed phones under ₹40K. The company has taken time to craft an absolutely stunning glass slab that is easy on the eyes and the hands.

DISPLAY

Honor has made some tall claims about the Honor 90's display. They claim it is the best display in this price range from a user's perspective owing to the fact that it comes with 3,840 Hz PWM Dimming.

There's not a lot of discourse yet about the harms of low PWM levels and how they affect our eyes in the long-term. I applaud Honor for caring about this when many flagships in the market don't, but we won't know the full extent of the benefits until the harmful effects have been studied further. Now PWM dimming aside, this is a feature-packed display. The content watched on this screen looks extremely crisp and quite vibrant. Viewing angles are

fantastic and sunlight visibility is excellent as well. I tested 1,524 nits of peak brightness under sunlight, which is superb. The display is also HDR10+ certified and supports 10-bit colour. There's also fast 120 Hz refresh rate support along with the option to choose Adaptive refresh rate where the phone changes it according to the task and its demand.

PERFORMANCE

Now here's where the Honor 90 falters a bit. Moving on to CPU benchmarks, the Honor 90 scores lower than most of its competitors. The OnePlus Nord 3, POCO F5, and iQOO Neo 7 Pro blaze past the Honor 90, but the Moto Edge 40 lags behind. In GeekBench, the Honor 90 is around the middle of the pack in PCMark Work with a good score of 12,460.

In GPU benchmarks, the Honor 90 lags behind yet again in both 3D Mark Wild Life Extreme and the GFXBench tests. So, this is definitely not the best phone for power users and gamers. When I played Call of Duty: Mobile on the Honor 90, I got pretty stable frame rates in the beginning on High Graphics, however, after about 10-15 minutes the phone started heating up and throttling, making some frame skips happen along the way.

To test throttling, I fired up the CPU Throttling Test where the Honor 90 throttled to 60 per cent of its maximum performance in merely 15 minutes – this is pretty poor throttling performance and you're going to feel the performance drop when the phone performs intensive tasks for longer periods.

In normal day-to-day usage though the phone serves you pretty well. If you're performing heavy-duty tasks such as recording video, editing photos, or gaming for longer periods, the phone will end up heating and you will feel some lag and stutters. The phone ships with Android 13 with MagicOS 7.1 on top. The company promises two years of software updates and three years of security patches which is on the lower side. In my opinion, three years should be standard, especially on phones above ₹30K. Most third-party apps can be uninstalled, but Honor apps stay put.